MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 3: Drama - Historical Development

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Indian drama develops through interacting classical, regional, folk, colonial, and modern performance traditions rather than a single straight line.

Start with a picture

Theatre can happen in a formal auditorium, a village square, a ritual setting, or a street. Its meaning depends on bodies, music, space, language, and spectators as well as written dialogue.

1. Classical performance and the Natyashastra

The Natyashastra, traditionally associated with Bharata, theorises performance through acting, music, movement, and aesthetic response. **Bhava** concerns represented emotional states; **rasa** concerns the aesthetic experience these can make possible for an audience.

Rasa is not merely the emotion felt by an actor. The relation between representation and reception matters. The text’s authorship and dating are complex; avoid presenting a precise unsupported birth date for its traditional author.

2. Classical dramatists

Bhasa, Kalidasa, and Bhavabhuti are important figures in Sanskrit drama. Kalidasa’s Abhijnanasakuntalam offers an example of love, memory, separation, and recognition. Their works use inherited stories but give them specific dramatic arrangements.

Classical literature is one major strand, not proof that all Indian performance originated in a single text or language.

3. Regional and folk traditions

Forms such as jatra, tamasha, nautanki, yakshagana, and other local performances combine storytelling, song, movement, and community participation in different ways. Labels and practices vary by region and period.

Loknatya points towards popular or folk theatrical traditions. Their flexibility and audience relationships matter to later experiments. Do not dismiss them as unfinished versions of a

supposedly superior written drama.

4. Colonial contact and translation

Colonial cities supported new theatres, educational institutions, and amateur performance. Shakespearean and Sanskrit works circulated through translation. These encounters altered expectations of plot, realism, acting, and public debate.

Translation is itself an act of interpretation. A regional-language play, its English translation, and its staged versions may address different audiences.

5. Modern theatre’s varied purposes

Social drama examines institutions and everyday conflict. Historical drama reworks the past to question the present. Amateur companies, including Kannada theatrical networks, helped develop performance cultures beyond professional commercial venues.

The Indian People’s Theatre Association, founded in the 1940s, connected cultural work with political mobilisation. Street theatre can address labour, discrimination, and civic conflict in public space, often with limited resources and direct audience contact.

6. How to write about a tradition

Name a form, explain a feature, and show the resulting audience relationship. A list of playwrights without performance context is incomplete. Likewise, a text’s publication language does not exhaust the multilingual world from which its performance emerges.

Quick check

1. Is rasa simply an actor’s private feeling? **No; aesthetic reception is central.**
2. Are folk forms merely primitive classical drama? **No.**
3. Does translation leave a play entirely unchanged? **No; interpretation and audience matter.**

Build an exam answer

1. Reject a single-origin or single-line model.
2. Explain Natyashastra, bhava, and rasa.
3. Give classical and regional examples.
4. Discuss translation and modern institutions.
5. Use public performance to illustrate changing audience relations.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not collapse all regional forms into one practice or treat the traditional attribution of a treatise as a precisely documented modern biography.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Explain why Indian theatre must be studied as a plural performance history.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Indian theatre cannot be adequately described as one tradition advancing towards a single modern model. Classical Sanskrit drama, regional performance, folk narrative, ritual practices, and colonial institutions interact without becoming identical. Their differences concern language, space, social purpose, and the relationship between performer and spectator.

The Natyashastra provides an influential vocabulary for performance and aesthetic response. Yet its importance should not erase forms whose practices developed through different community histories. A study of theatre therefore needs both conceptual frameworks and attention to the particular conditions of an event.

Colonial contact introduced further exchanges through translation, education, and urban performance. Modern dramatists could use realism, historical material, myth, or popular forms to question contemporary institutions. Street theatre and the IPTA tradition demonstrate that dramatic value is not restricted to elaborate buildings or a privately reading audience.

A strong answer connects this plurality with interpretation. The same story may acquire new emphasis through a changed language, space, or audience. Performance history consequently helps explain why Indian English drama cannot be separated completely from the other languages and embodied traditions with which it continues to work.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Discuss the use of Rasa theory in Indian Classical Dance.
2. Comment on the type of Loknatya performed across the country.
3. Trace the connection between Sanskrit and Indian Drama tradition
4. Analyse the key features of Street Theatre.
5. What is the relevance of Shakuntala’s translation in Indian theatre?
6. Comment on social drama.
7. Discuss the features of Modern Indian drama.

8. What are the important features of Natya Shastra?